

Short Paper:

Redevelopment of the Sanford B. Ladd School

Case Study Analysis

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QSO 440: Project Management

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May 30, 2026

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The redevelopment of the Sanford B. Ladd School into a community resource hub is a complex, multi-phase initiative that integrates historic preservation, community governance, public sector funding, and long-term program development. This analysis evaluates the project's strengths, challenges, planning effectiveness, Work Breakdown Structure (WBS), risk management approach, and implementation strategy. The purpose is to provide leadership with a clear understanding of the project's viability and the organizational readiness required to support successful execution.

Pros and Cons of the Project

Pros

The project delivers substantial community and economic value. Transforming a long vacant historic school into a multi service hub directly addresses neighborhood needs such as job training, food, necessity, and service access, youth and family programming, community meeting and celebration spaces, and digital inclusion. The project also stimulates local employment during construction and operation, strengthens community cohesion through shared governance, and preserves a significant neighborhood landmark. The funding strategy aligns well with federal and local programs designed to support community facilities and neighborhood revitalization, including HUD CDBG, the CCED Sales Tax program, and EDA Public Works grants (City of Kansas City, 2024; HUD, 2023; EDA, 2023).

The hybrid labor model, which combines skilled trades with local hiring for unskilled work, reduces costs and increases community ownership. This approach aligns with best practices in community driven development and enhances long-term sustainability (Lakey, 2026a).

Cons

The project's complexity introduces several risks. Historic buildings often contain unknown conditions that can increase cost and schedule variability. The 36-to-38-month timeline requires sustained community engagement and consistent governance, which can be challenging in volunteer-driven environments. The project also depends on multiple funding sources, each with its own compliance requirements, increasing administrative burden. Additionally, the dual focus on physical renovation and program development requires careful coordination to prevent misalignment between construction progress and operational readiness (Lakey, 2026a).

A further organizational challenge is the reliance on a community governed model during a multi-year redevelopment effort. While this structure strengthens long term ownership, it also requires leadership capacity, conflict resolution mechanisms, and continuity planning to ensure that decision-making remains consistent even as volunteers change over time. Without intentional leadership development, the governance structure itself could become a bottleneck.

Effectiveness of Project Initiation and Planning Activities

The project's initiation activities are strong and align with established project management standards. The proposed charter provides a clear foundation by defining the project purpose, major deliverables, governance expectations, and funding constraints (Lakey, 2026a). It also establishes the community driven identity of the project and clarifies which elements belong in the initial scope versus later operational phases. This clarity reduces the risk of scope drift and

provides a stable reference point for decision making, consistent with recommended practices for project initiation (Meredith et al., 2021).

Planning activities demonstrate similar strength. The proposal includes a realistic timeline based on comparable redevelopment data (Drexel Tech, 2026), a clear scope statement, and a detailed description of required resources (Lakey, 2026a). Early identification of partners such as Kansas City Parks and Recreation and the Kansas City Public Library supports long-term sustainability. The planning process reflects industry standard practices for scope definition, activity sequencing, and early risk identification (Meredith et al., 2021). Together, these initiation and planning activities provide a strong foundation for the project's long-term success.

Development of the Work Breakdown Structure

The project WBS is comprehensive and technically sound. It decomposes the project into detailed activities across pre-development, building renovation, community garden development, administrative preparation, and project closeout. Each activity includes durations, predecessors, resource assignments, and responsibility designations, which supports accurate scheduling and critical path analysis (Lakey, 2026b).

The WBS reflects best practices in hierarchical decomposition and deliverable based structuring, which are essential for managing complex projects with interdependent workstreams (Meredith et al., 2021). It also accounts for parallel workstreams, such as administrative and program development occurring alongside construction, which is critical for ensuring operational readiness at project completion. Because the WBS integrates both construction and organizational development tasks, it provides leadership with a clear view of the full scope and sequencing required to bring the facility online.

Risk Management Analysis and Plan

The risk register demonstrates a proactive and structured approach to risk management. It includes both negative and positive risks, each with probability and severity ratings, calculated risk values, response strategies, and assigned owners. High value risks such as environmental review delays, cost overruns, and skilled labor shortages are identified early, allowing for mitigation strategies such as early testing, contingency budgeting, and contractor prequalification (Lakey, 2026c).

Medium level risks, including volunteer shortages, weather delays, and governance bottlenecks, are assigned monitoring strategies that reflect their potential to disrupt the schedule without requiring major plan changes. The inclusion of positive risks, such as opportunities for additional grant funding or strong volunteer turnout, aligns with modern risk management frameworks that emphasize opportunity management as well as threat mitigation (Meredith et al., 2021).

The risk register also reinforces the connection between the WBS and budgeting approaches. Bottom-up budgeting reveals risks tied to specific work packages, while top-down budgeting highlights risks associated with overall funding ceilings (Lakey, 2026c). Clear ownership assignments strengthen accountability and ensure timely response.

Implementation Strategy

The implementation strategy is phased, realistic, and aligned with public sector construction norms. The pre-development phase focuses on community engagement, governance formation, environmental review, and architectural design. The building renovation phase follows a logical sequence from abatement and site preparation to exterior restoration, MEP installation, interior

construction, and final inspections (Lakey, 2026b). The community garden and administrative development phases run in parallel, supporting operational readiness at project completion.

To ensure effective implementation, leadership should prioritize structured communication channels, milestone-based progress reviews, and clear escalation pathways for decision-making. Because the project includes multiple parallel workstreams, coordination mechanisms such as integrated schedule reviews and cross-functional check-ins will be essential. The strategy also emphasizes community ownership through a cooperative or land trust model, which strengthens long-term sustainability.

Integrating program development during construction ensures that the facility will be ready to operate immediately upon opening. The community garden, which is completed earlier in the timeline, provides an opportunity for a mid-project engagement milestone. While the first harvest offers a visible sign of progress that can reinforce community enthusiasm during the longer building renovation period, the formal grand opening will occur once the full facility is operational, including the job center, food pantry, clothing closet, classrooms, computer labs, and community event space. This final milestone marks the transition from construction to service delivery and establishes the hub as a fully functioning community asset (Lakey, 2026a).

Conclusion

The redevelopment of the Sanford B. Ladd School is a strategically aligned and community centered project with strong initiation, planning, scope definition, and risk management foundations. The WBS provides a clear structure for coordinating complex workstreams, while the risk register offers a proactive framework for managing uncertainty. The implementation strategy reflects realistic timelines and community values. Although the project carries inherent

risks due to its scale and historic nature, the planning documents and analytical tools developed to date position the project for long-term success. To support this success, leadership should maintain consistent oversight, invest in governance capacity, and ensure that communication remains transparent throughout the multi-year timeline. With continued attention to governance, communication, and risk mitigation, the project has the potential to deliver lasting social and economic benefits to the Oak Park neighborhood.

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